

THE NARRATIVE STACK · A READING

The Giery *Voice*

A Working Assessment of Adam Giery's Narrative Voice



VOICE PROFILE · PATTERN LEXICON · STORY BANK · THE METHOD APPLIED

How to Read This Document

This is an assessment, not a tribute. Every claim about Adam's voice is anchored to his own words, set off in the bordered evidence blocks below, with the source named and linked where it lives online. Where the assessment identifies a weakness, the document does not stop at diagnosis. Part IV takes his actual sentences and his actual stories, applies the recommendations, and shows the rework so the standard is visible, not theoretical.

The corpus reviewed: three published long-form essays ([Cultivating a Laboratory Culture](#), [The Gratitude Entrepreneur](#), [Meet the Metaverse](#)), the Forbes book chapter draft, the VoyageTampa interview, the Entrepreneur and LA Weekly bios, the 2025 Tampa Bay 40 Under 40 application, the 2026 drafted LinkedIn posts, and [adamgiery.com](#) including the [Capital Class](#) platform.

The Thesis

Adam writes like a philosophical operator: an educator turned dealmaker who processes business through metaphor, compresses lessons into aphorisms, and frames ambition through Stoic patience. Call the voice the Educator-Explorer. The register is aspirational pragmatism. The signature cadence is a long, layered idea followed by a short, quotable landing.

The headline diagnosis, and the through-line of this entire document: Adam is a metaphor-maker and an aphorist who needs to become a storyteller. The frameworks are real. The worldview is consistent across every format he touches. What is missing is scene-craft, the concrete moment with names, stakes, and consequence that makes the maxims earned rather than asserted. He has done it exactly once in the corpus, and that once proves he can.

PART ONE

The Voice Profile

What the voice sounds like when it is working, the six moves that make it his, and the tics that dilute it.

This section is the standard. It defines what the voice sounds like when it is working, names the six signature moves that make it his, and lists the tics that dilute it. Treat it as the sheet any editor, ghostwriter, or collaborator works from.

I. Tone: Aspirational Pragmatism

Adam's tone fuses two registers that rarely coexist. The aspirational register reaches for horizons, summits, and exploration. The pragmatic register insists on patience, process, and protection of the downside. Neither dominates. The voice works because the dreamer and the operator speak in the same paragraph.

"Entrepreneurship is in many ways to be an explorer, standing on the front of the boat, peering off into the horizon, confident in one's ability to find land."

Source: VoyageTampa interview draft (Voyage_Final_Review.docx)

"However, I take no risks that could potentially take down our business and negatively affect the team who count on me."

Source: Forbes book chapter draft (Adam-Chapter-REDO-RB-JB-Edit.docx)

Assessment: this duality is the brand. Any piece written in his name should carry both poles. A piece that is all summit reads as a motivational poster. A piece that is all process reads as a consultant's memo. He is neither.

2. Cadence: Build, Then Land

His best paragraphs layer an idea across one or two long sentences, then land it with a short declarative that could survive alone on a slide. The long sentence carries the thinking. The short sentence carries the conviction.

"In my eyes, the only way to create is to experiment, and the only way to experiment is to fail. That's laboratory culture."

Source: [Cultivating a Laboratory Culture \(adamgiery.com, Aug 2024\)](https://adamgiery.com)

The 2026 LinkedIn drafts show this instinct fully matured for the platform, where he opens cold with a one-line thesis before any context arrives:

"There are moments in a career that create pause."

"Hosting the Federal Reserve of Jacksonville was one of them."

Source: Drafted LinkedIn Posts Compilation, 2026 (Drafted_Posts_Compilation.docx)

Assessment: protect the alternation. When his drafting runs loose, the long sentences multiply and the landings disappear. The edit pass should always ask: where does this paragraph land, and is the landing under ten words?

3. The Six Signature Moves

Move 1: Extended Metaphor as Argument

This is the load-bearing wall. Adam does not decorate arguments with metaphor; he builds the argument inside one. The laboratory versus the military order. Concentric circles of expertise. The trail and the summit. The metaphor is the logic.

"Envision your company functioning like a scientific laboratory vs. the parochial military order. The scientists are provided the flexibility to experiment, fail, and repeat."

Source: [Cultivating a Laboratory Culture \(adamgiery.com, Aug 2024\)](https://adamgiery.com)

"When our team reaches a summit, we gaze the view only to realize we reached the top of a lower mountain, and we have much more work to do to reach higher peaks."

Source: Forbes book chapter draft (Adam-Chapter-REDO-RB-JB-Edit.docx)

Move 2: The Named Concept

He instinctively brands his ideas. Most executives describe; Adam labels. Laboratory Culture, the Gratitude Pandemic, Unmistakable Client Value, Distillation of Focus, Living and Learning, Leader-to-Leader, Daddy School. This is rare and commercially valuable, and Part II inventories every coined term with a recommendation.

Move 3: The Mirrored Pair

Antithesis is his favorite rhetorical engine: two terms set against each other, often with a chiasmic turn that flips the second half back on the first.

"Some clients you build. Others build you. AMI is both."

Source: Drafted LinkedIn Posts Compilation, 2026 (Drafted_Posts_Compilation.docx)

"The real question, will you be an owner or a renter when that time comes?"

Source: [Meet the Metaverse \(adamgiery.com, Jun 2022\)](https://adamgiery.com)

"The arrival of a title is not the ascension of a prescribed role."

Source: Forbes book chapter draft (Adam-Chapter-REDO-RB-JB-Edit.docx)

Move 4: The Handoff Question

He pivots and closes on rhetorical questions that transfer the idea to the reader. The question is not decoration; it is how he exits.

"Do you visit Instagram to view the platform or the content?"

Source: [Meet the Metaverse \(adamgiery.com, Jun 2022\)](https://adamgiery.com)

"What could you or your business achieve if you were without the physical limitations of space and time?"

Source: [Meet the Metaverse \(adamgiery.com, Jun 2022\)](https://adamgiery.com)

Move 5: Proof by Timestamp and Number

Credibility, in Adam's writing, arrives as precision. He does not say he rose quickly; he gives the clock. He does not say the firm grew; he gives the figures. The specificity of the milestone is part of the style.

"After sixteen months as an employee, I earned full partner, and twelve months thereafter, Managing Partner. Five years to the day of obtaining Partnership, we acquired Strategos."

Source: VoyageTampa interview draft (Voyage_Final_Review.docx)

"On the traditional metrics, we surpassed \$10M in run rate, grew 70% YoY, and launched a partnership with the nation's largest education investment bank."

Source: 2025 Tampa Bay 40 Under 40 application draft

Move 6: Collective Deflection

He redirects credit to the team as a reflex, and it reads as conviction rather than modesty theater because it appears even in contexts built to celebrate the individual, like an awards application.

"My success is a collective reflection of many small steps taken by countless leaders to support a vision of a broader mission."

Source: 2025 Tampa Bay 40 Under 40 application draft

4. The Tension to Manage: Humility Versus Superlative

The deflection above coexists with superlative self-positioning, sometimes in the same document. Both impulses are authentic to him. Left unedited, they collide.

"Today, I lead the nation's leading education management consultancy..."

Source: VoyageTampa interview draft (Voyage_Final_Review.docx)

"...he's transformed the organization into one of the most sought-after advisory firms in the \$7-trillion-dollar global education market."

Source: LA Weekly bio draft (Giery_LA_Weekly_TonyEdit.docx)

Assessment: the rule going forward is simple. Superlatives attach to the firm, the team, or the mission, never to Adam in first person. Let third parties make the claims about him; his own prose carries the numbers and lets the reader do the math. This protects the gratitude brand from undermining itself.

5. The Tics: A Banned and Watch List

Five patterns dilute the voice. Each is documented from his own pages.

Tic 1: Hedge Phrases

He softens claims he has already earned. The hedges read as throat-clearing from a writer whose whole brand is conviction.

"The quiet quitting phenomenon and increased organizational dysfunction, in my opinion, are directly correlated to a gratitude shortage."

Source: [The Gratitude Entrepreneur \(adamgiery.com, Aug 2024\)](#)

Watch list: "in my opinion," "in many respects," "in my eyes," "candidly," "I believe" when stacked more than once per piece. The fix is deletion. The sentence above is stronger with the hedge removed and no other change.

Tic 2: Latinate Drift

Under pressure to sound formal, the prose reaches for abstraction: endeavors, pursuits, accentuated, germinated, particularized, syndication. The vocabulary floats away from the concrete world where his metaphors live.

"Value-based businesses invest more significant sums into the products or experiences of their client, and in turn, the goodwill that sprouts from this practice is almost incalculable."

Source: [The Gratitude Entrepreneur \(adamgiery.com, Aug 2024\)](#)

This sentence is reworked in Part IV as Demonstration A.

Tic 3: Metaphor Stacking

The signature strength, overdriven, becomes the signature weakness. When two images arrive in one clause, both lose.

"...the more seasoned you become as an entrepreneur, the radio frequency or arteriogram in business will quickly fluctuate up and down to where the blip becomes tighter."

Source: Forbes book chapter draft (Adam-Chapter-REDO-RB-JB-Edit.docx)

The rule: one metaphor per paragraph, and it must finish its work before the next one starts. "The Gratitude Pandemic" belongs on this list too; the name fights itself, since the piece argues there is a shortage of gratitude, not an outbreak of it. Part II recommends a rename.

Tic 4: Passive Constructions at Key Moments

His most important rituals are sometimes narrated with the actor removed, which drains them of exactly the personal authority they are meant to carry.

"No matter the role at Strategos Group, on your first day, a communication is sent from me to the entire staff cc'd."

Source: [Cultivating a Laboratory Culture \(adamgiery.com, Aug 2024\)](https://adamgiery.com)

"A communication is sent" buries the most interesting fact in the sentence: that the Managing Partner personally emails the entire company about a new hire. Demonstration B in Part IV rebuilds this moment.

Tic 5: Summary Where a Scene Should Be

The deepest craft gap. He tells the reader that experiments failed, that culture yielded businesses, that moments mattered, but almost never shows one happening. The lone full scene in the corpus is also the best passage he has published:

"In my case, the inspiration of the Metaverse for entrepreneurship and education led me to a late-night purchase at Target. At first, the Metaverse appeared shiny and new, but over time, I realized the program's infancy."

Source: [Meet the Metaverse \(adamgiery.com, Jun 2022\)](https://adamgiery.com)

A Managing Partner driving to Target at midnight to buy a VR headset is worth a thousand words about innovation mindset. He wrote it once. The recommendation across every future piece: find the Target run inside the topic before drafting begins.

6. The Three Modes Problem

The corpus reveals three distinct Adams. The Essayist (the published long-form pieces) is polished, metaphor-forward, and structurally sound. The Live Drafter (the raw chapter material) is idea-rich but syntactically loose, with run-ons and dropped words. The Bio Writer (the magazine bios and applications) drifts toward press-release superlatives. None of these is wrong; the risk is that editors encounter one mode and flatten the others toward it. This profile exists so that all three modes get edited toward one standard: the Essayist's discipline, the Live Drafter's energy, the Bio Writer's proof points, minus each mode's liabilities.

PART TWO

The Pattern Lexicon

Every concept he has named and every line built to travel. Nothing here should be reinvented, diluted, or accidentally retired.

Two inventories follow. The first catalogs every concept Adam has named, with a status call on each. The second harvests his aphorisms, the lines built to travel. Together they are the raw material for the branding conversation: nothing here should be reinvented, diluted, or accidentally retired.

Table I. Coined Frameworks and Named Concepts

TERM	WHAT IT CARRIES	WHERE IT LIVES	STATUS / RECOMMENDATION
Laboratory Culture	Experimentation over perfection; fail, never the same way twice; process rewarded alongside outcome.	Lab Culture essay; Voyage; 40 Under 40; Forbes chapter	Flagship. Codify as the keynote and probable book spine. Owns the category.
Concentric Circles	Expand from a defended home base of expertise outward into adjacent markets; consolidate when a circle goes too far.	Forbes chapter	High potential, underpublished. Deserves its own essay; currently buried in a profile.
Distillation of Focus	Fewer, deeper commitments; the anti-hustle math of giving 100% to a few things.	Voyage; Forbes chapter; 40 Under 40	Strong but unnamed in public work. Claim the phrase formally.
The Gratitude Pandemic	Gratitude as cultural infrastructure; appreciation as compensated company practice.	Gratitude Entrepreneur essay	Rename. The metaphor inverts the argument (the piece describes a shortage, not an outbreak). The underlying material is strong.
Unmistakable Client Value	The Strategos North Star; client care reviewed weekly as an operating discipline.	Gratitude Entrepreneur essay	Promote. This is an internal phrase ready for external life.
Living and Learning	Mission shorthand: healthcare is living, education is learning.	Voyage; site copy	Protect. Clean, ownable mission language. Use consistently.
Leader-to-Leader	Invitation-only tableside convenings; not a panel, not a fundraiser.	2026 LinkedIn drafts	Live event brand. Keep the triad (Intimate. Invited. Inspired.) as its fixed signature.
Primary Source	Going directly to the people who hold the truth, named as a component of the Strategos approach.	Vistria post, 2026 drafts	Emerging. Worth claiming before it stays a throwaway line; pairs naturally with his educator identity.

Daddy School	Structured lessons with his children; the educator identity at home.	40 Under 40	Humanizing asset. Deploy sparingly and only in personal-register pieces.
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Table 2. The Aphorism Inventory

These are the lines that already work. The recommendation column flags which are signature (repeatable as identity), which need attribution care, and which are one-use.

THE LINE	SOURCE	NOTE
"Fail, just not the same way twice."	Lab Culture essay; Voyage; 40 Under 40	The signature. Appears in three forms across the corpus; standardize this short form everywhere.
"Success dulls."	Forbes chapter	Two words, full thesis. Underused. Strong essay or talk title.
"The arrival of a title is not the ascension of a prescribed role."	Forbes chapter	Signature-grade chiasmus. Tighten slightly for spoken use: a title arrives; the role still has to be earned.
"Some clients you build. Others build you."	AMI Kids post, 2026 drafts	Best recent line. Model for future post closers.
"Data guides, but qualitative truth gives it meaning."	Fed luncheon post, 2026 drafts	Strong, and on-brand for Primary Source. Keep.
"Will you be an owner or a renter when that time comes?"	Metaverse essay	The handoff question at its best; the essay around it has aged, the device has not.
"No one grows successful in answering emails."	Voyage; Lab Culture essay	Caution: closely echoes Cal Newport, whom he cites elsewhere. Either attribute every time or retire to avoid borrowed-line risk.
"We reached the top of a lower mountain."	Forbes chapter	Quiet, excellent, and unrepeatable. Build a piece around it.
"It is easy to confuse activities for outcomes."	Voyage (adapted)	Sharpen to the four-word form: activities are not outcomes.
"Intimate. Invited. Inspired."	Leader-to-Leader post, 2026 drafts	Event-brand triad. Reserve exclusively for Leader-to-Leader.

One device-level note belongs in the lexicon rather than the tables: the fragment triad. "Not a panel. Not a fundraiser." shows the negative-definition version, defining a thing by what it refuses to be. It is among his most effective short-form moves and should be a deliberate tool, not an accident of drafting.

PART THREE

The Story Bank Inventory

The over-used material is summary. The under-used material is scene. The development work is sitting with the undertold five.

Adam's stories divide into three categories. Load-bearing stories carry the brand and should keep working. Overexposed stories have been told in identical summary form too many times and need either a rest or a definitive scene-level telling that retires the summary version. Undertold stories are sitting in the corpus as single sentences, holding more value than anything currently in rotation.

STORY	WHERE IT APPEARS	STATUS	ASSESSMENT
The Origin Arc: learning disability, the mother who taught, the teachers who intervened	Every bio; Voyage; 40 Under 40; LA Weekly; site	Overexposed as summary	The spine of the brand, told identically each time. Needs one definitive scene-level telling (a specific classroom, a specific teacher, a specific day) that becomes the canonical version. After that, allude rather than repeat.
The 2008 layoff and the 120 seventh-graders	Voyage; 40 Under 40; Forbes chapter	Load-bearing	His best-deployed proof point. The number 120 does real work. Keep.
Five Years to the Day (the acquisition)	Voyage; 40 Under 40; chapter	Overexposed as a stat	Currently a timestamp, never a story. What happened on that day? Who called whom? Tell it once as a scene; the stat then carries the scene's weight forever after.
March 13, 2020: lost a month of payroll in a day, a year of it by month-end; zero layoffs, zero debt	Voyage	Undertold	The highest-stakes story he has, told in two sentences. This is a feature-length crisis narrative compressed into a footnote. Top development priority.
The First-Day Email	Lab Culture essay; Voyage; 40 Under 40	Undertold as scene	Told three times, always in summary, once in passive voice. Rebuilt in Part IV as Demonstration B.
The Late-Night Target Run (the Oculus purchase)	Metaverse essay	Model scene	The only true scene in the corpus and the template for everything: a leader, an impulse, a parking lot, a lesson. Every future essay needs its Target run.
AMI Kids and Mike: fifteen years, parallel leadership journeys	2026 LinkedIn drafts	Emerging signature	Two leaders who grew up in the work together. Warm, specific, and produces his best aphorism. Develop into long form.
The Fed Luncheon	2026 LinkedIn drafts	Fresh	Twenty leaders, no filters, the Fed taking qualitative truth back to a rate-setting process. A Primary Source story wearing a news peg. Use soon, while current.

The Caddy	Forbes chapter	Portable parable	Not better than you, but has walked the course a hundred more times. A teaching story that travels across topics. Keep in rotation.
The UCF Return: Order of Pegasus to keynoting 30 Under 30's anniversary, family in the arena	40 Under 40	Undertold	A full-circle story currently locked inside an application no one will read. Free it.
Tampa Therapy: doubling a PTSD and trauma clinic in Ybor	40 Under 40	Undertold, handle with care	Potentially the most meaningful mission proof he has, and almost invisible. Requires careful, patient-respecting treatment, likely centered on the why rather than the clinic's clients.
Daddy School	40 Under 40	Undertold	The educator identity made domestic. One short personal piece, maximum, per year. Scarcity protects it.

The pattern across this table is the same finding stated in Part I: the over-used material is summary, and the under-used material is scene. The development work ahead is not finding new stories. It is sitting with the five undertold ones, in interview, until the specifics surface: the room, the hour, the sentence somebody said.

PART FOUR

The Method Applied

*Assessment without demonstration is opinion. Two findings, fixed on the page,
in his own material.*

Assessment without demonstration is opinion. This section takes the two highest-value findings, Latinate drift and summary-where-scene-belongs, and applies the recommended fixes to Adam's actual text. The rework runs his material through the editorial method this practice uses for all client narrative work: lead with a human in a moment, write in active voice, let the scene earn the maxim, and close by handing the reader a question. One firewall note for execution: the method shapes the work, but in anything published under Adam's name, the method itself stays invisible. The reader should meet Adam, not the process.

Demonstration A. The Sentence: Killing the Abstraction

BEFORE

"Value-based businesses invest more significant sums into the products or experiences of their client, and in turn, the goodwill that sprouts from this practice is almost incalculable."

Source: [The Gratitude Entrepreneur \(adamgiery.com, Aug 2024\)](https://adamgiery.com)

DIAGNOSIS

Twenty-eight words, zero pictures. "Invest more significant sums" is a number hiding from itself. "Goodwill that sprouts" plants a garden metaphor that nothing else in the piece waters. "Almost incalculable" hedges and inflates in the same breath. Meanwhile the writer who built an entire essay on a laboratory, and who measures his own career in months-to-partner, is nowhere in this sentence. The fix is not ornamentation. It is returning the sentence to his own native moves: the mirrored pair, the short landing, the concrete ledger.

AFTER

"Great businesses overinvest in the client's experience. You will never find the return on a balance sheet. You will find it in who calls you first."

Reworked per assessment recommendations

WHAT CHANGED

Twenty-eight words became twenty-five, and every abstraction became an object: a balance sheet, a phone call. The mirrored pair (never find it / will find it) is his own Move 3, borrowed back from his best work. The landing is seven words. Nothing was added that he does not already do; the edit simply held the sentence to his own standard.

Demonstration B. The Story: From Summary to Scene

The first-day email is Adam's most repeated proof of Laboratory Culture, and he has never once shown it happening. Three tellings, three summaries:

"No matter the role at Strategos Group, on your first day, a communication is sent from me to the entire staff cc'd. In summary, it says, 'Welcome to the team. The expectation is experimentation. We want you to be failing, but not the same failures twice.'"

Source: [Cultivating a Laboratory Culture \(adamgiery.com, Aug 2024\)](#)

"On the first day of employment, we email all new hires encouraging them to be trying, be failing, just not the same mistakes twice."

Source: VoyageTampa interview draft (Voyage_Final_Review.docx)

"Every new hire receives one message on their first day: fail, just not the same way twice."

Source: 2025 Tampa Bay 40 Under 40 application draft

DIAGNOSIS

The third version has the best compression; the first has the best detail (the entire company is copied) and the worst construction ("a communication is sent" removes Adam from his own ritual). None of the three contains a human being reacting. The reader is told the email exists and told what it means, but never gets to stand in the room when somebody opens it. That reaction is where the story's proof lives: a culture claim is only believable when you see a person not believing it yet.

AFTER

"Before a new hire at Strategos opens a single project file, they open an email from me. The whole company is copied. It says, in so many words: welcome to the team. We expect you to experiment. We want you to fail, just never the same way twice.

I have watched people read it on their first morning. Some smile. Some read it twice, certain there is a catch.

There is no catch. There is a question underneath it, and it is not only mine to answer: what is the first thing your people hear from you, and would they believe it?"

Reworked per assessment recommendations

WHAT CHANGED

The passive construction died first: the email now comes from a person, and the buried detail (the company-wide cc) moved to its own short sentence where it can do its work. A human entered the frame, reading and doubting, which converts the claim into evidence. The signature aphorism survived untouched, because the inventory in Part II exists precisely so lines like that never get paraphrased away. And the ending performs his own Move 4, the handoff question, now aimed at the reader's company instead of his. The result is still recognizably Adam: his ritual, his line, his move. It is simply Adam shown rather than Adam summarized.

Where This Goes Next

Three workstreams fall out of this assessment. First, the branding pass: the lexicon in Part II is ready to be organized into a named system, with Laboratory Culture as the flagship, Concentric Circles and Distillation as supporting frameworks, and a decision on renaming the gratitude concept. Second, the editor's standard: Part I condenses into a one-page voice sheet that governs all three of his writing modes and travels with any piece that carries his name. Third, story development: structured interview sessions against the five untold stories in Part III, with March 13, 2020 first in the chair, conducted until each one has its Target run.

This document is built to be argued with. Mark it up.

